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By Sebastian Starcevic, Max Giera · Sep 16, 2026, 7:33 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — Ursula von der Leyen wanted to make a splash in her big speech. Instead, the European Commission president's audacious offer of making Canada the EU's first "associate member" has created a major diplomatic headache.

The idea was not run past European capitals in advance and has caused considerable confusion, four diplomats told POLITICO. Ottawa also appears to be distancing itself from the label — hours before Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney is set to give his own speech to the European Parliament.

Von der Leyen dropped the bombshell proposal during her State of the Union address Wednesday, directly addressing Carney from the floor of the Parliament.

"I would like to work with you on opening the door for Canada to be the first associate member of the EU," she said, drawing thunderous applause from MEPs and an embrace from Carney.

There is another big problem: No one seems to know exactly what associate membership would entail.

And within hours, Canada was tamping down expectations.

"We're not there," Jonathan Wilkinson, Canada's incoming ambassador to the EU, told reporters in Strasbourg when asked about associate membership. "What we're focused on is actually driving results."

That leaves von der Leyen having publicly offered up a new status that the EU hasn't agreed to create or settled on a definition for — and which Canada itself doesn't appear exactly eager to embrace.

A 'dangerous' strategy

The idea didn't come out of nowhere. As U.S. tariffs and Donald Trump's "51st state" threats strain ties, Canada is seeking to reduce its dependence on its neighbor, which receives roughly 70% of its exports, by deepening economic and security ties with Europe.

Ottawa has been exploring whether it can establish an unusually close relationship with the EU, the Wall Street Journal first reported last week. Carney publicly confirmed the broader ambition on Sunday, saying Canada was not seeking EU membership but rather a "unique alliance" with the bloc.

But von der Leyen's decision to announce the proposal, at the biggest annual set piece of her political calendar, caught EU member countries off guard, according to four European diplomats who said their

governments were not informed. They were granted anonymity, like others in this article, to speak candidly about their reactions the proposal.

One diplomat slammed the secrecy as “dangerous” and “unwise,” pointing out that von der Leyen had not even raised the idea at a recent lunch with EU ambassadors. Another diplomat said the copy of the speech their government received in advance did not include the words associate membership.

And a different diplomat with knowledge of the discussions with Canada raised a different issue: “Nobody really knows what it [associate membership] means.”

While the Commission president is under no obligation to flag any of the speech’s content to capitals in advance, they would need to approve any formal plan to grant Canada an exceptional status.

The idea has also raised questions about whether Britain could seek a similar deal . But EU officials have moved quickly to rule that out, stressing the model is intended for countries that cannot join the bloc. “Unlike Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia, Norway and the U.K., Canada is not in Europe,” one senior EU official said. “It cannot join the EU.”

Under the EU treaties and the bloc’s established institutional practice, there is a sharp distinction between membership and partnership. The EU has close relationships with many non-member countries, but only its 27 members have a seat in the bloc’s core political institutions and a formal role in making EU law.

A new model of membership “would actually require a treaty change,” German Socialists and Democrats MEP René Repasi told POLITICO.

The lack of wide consultation was visible inside the Commission, too, with an official involved in enlargement telling POLITICO their team had not been involved in any discussions about the proposal and that they knew nothing about it.

The Commission’s spokesperson’s service did not immediately respond to request for comment.

Ottawa hits the brakes — ish

The response from Canada was hardly an unequivocal embrace.

Carney’s office welcomed Brussels’ broader push to deepen ties, saying after von der Leyen’s speech that Canada wanted to strengthen its relationship with the EU and move beyond the existing free-trade relationship to a “far stronger, more ambitious alliance.”

But Ottawa has been careful, at least publicly, to distinguish that ambition from any form of EU membership. Carney himself said last week he wanted a “unique” partnership with Brussels but shied away from using the words associate membership.

Even if Canada eventually warms to the idea, there is a much bigger question: What would associate membership actually mean?

It’s not hard to imagine what quasi-membership could entail, based on privileges extended to other non-members.

Iceland, Norway, Switzerland and Liechtenstein all participate in the EU’s single market via the European Economic Area and are in the Schengen passport-free zone, despite not being part of the EU.

Moldovans and Ukrainians can make calls and send texts in the EU without additional charges thanks to the bloc's "roam like at home" program.

Without treaty change, "what one could rather imagine is looking in the direction of the EEA," Repasi said, calling it "essentially an associate form of membership."

But the EEA model comes with its own complications. EEA countries are deeply integrated into the EU's regulatory system while having no vote when EU legislation is passed.

Associate membership wouldn't simply be about rebranding the EU's existing relationship with Canada or a euphemistic catch-all for a closer relationship, but creating a new category of partners for enhanced free trade and cooperation on areas including defense, AI and high-tech science, according to an EU official with knowledge of talks.

There would be no political rights or free movement, at least for now. Canada would be the first, but potentially not the only, country in the club: Australia, New Zealand, Singapore and Japan have all been mentioned as possible future members, the official added.

But a fifth diplomat was skeptical about what the result of such an arrangement would be and how it would materially differ from the close partnerships the EU already has with its allies.

A different diplomat pointed out that 10 EU countries have not yet even ratified the bloc's free trade agreement with Canada, CETA, which was signed almost a decade ago, while three have yet to approve the Strategic Partnership Agreement. A more daring pact would likely require the political enthusiasm of EU governments.

Germany also struck a cautious tone at a press conference on Wednesday.

"Canada is an especially close partner for Europe. That is why we are open to discussing new models of partnership," government spokesperson Stefan Kornelius said. But on the "associate member" label, he added: "I think we should give that some more thought."

Camille Gijs contributed reporting from Brussels. Zoya Sheftalovich contributed reporting from Strasbourg. Oliver Noyan contributed reporting from Berlin.

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